Turning the pages of history

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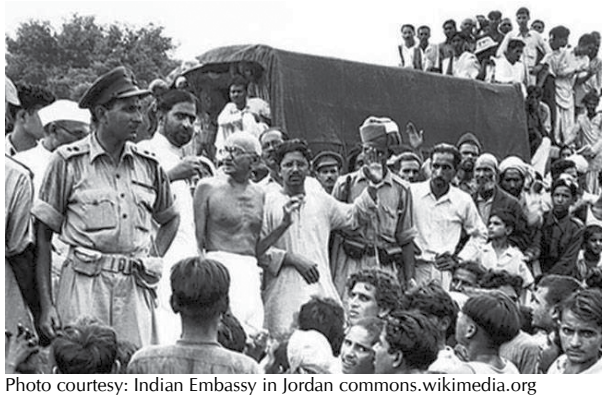
Non-violence – a weapon of the strong



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Satyagraha was a unique technique devised by Gandhiji to protest against the wrongdoings of the British Raj. He had used it successfully in South Africa and on his return to India, he used it first in Champaran to fight for the rights of the indigo cultivators.

Satyagraha was based on the twin principles of Satya (Truth) and Ahimsa (Non-violence). According to Gandhiji, "Non-violence is the greatest force at the disposal of mankind. It is mightier than the mightiest weapon of destruction devised by the ingenuity of man."

1. What do you think is the "mightiest weapon of destruction" devised by man? Why do you think so? Look at the pictures below for some options (nuclear weapons, biological warfare, chemical warfare) – or you can think of others.

Photo courtesy: www.unsplash.com

Photo courtesy: Frank Hurley – State Library of New South Wales, https://commons.wikimedia.org

Photo courtesy: Charles Levy – U.S. National Archives and Records Administration, https://commons.wikimedia.org/

When Gandhi announced the Salt Satyagraha, many Congress leaders including Gandhi's supporters were sceptical. "We were bewildered and could not fit in a national struggle with common salt," remembered Jawaharlal Nehru. Yet, in hindsight, historians agree that it was an act of political genius, for the British monopoly over the salt trade made it a prime example of the unfair policies of the Raj. Tens of thousands of protesters joined Gandhi when he gave the call for Civil Disobedience.

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2. Why do you think Gandhi chose to protest against the salt tax?
3. The British arrested some 60,000 people for participating in the Civil Disobedience campaign. Volunteers gladly went to jail and some even courted arrest. Why do you think they did this?

As Gandhi broke the Salt Law, he said "With this I am shaking the foundations of the British Empire."

In his 1950 biography of Gandhi, Louis Fischer wrote about the legacy of the Salt March: "India was now free," he writes. "Technically, legally, nothing had changed. India was still a British colony." And yet, after the Salt Satyagraha, "it was inevitable that Britain should some day refuse to rule India and that India should some day refuse to be ruled."

4. Why do you think Louis Fischer described India as "free" – even though (as we know) independence was still more than 15 years away?
5. Do you agree that Gandhi successfully shook "the foundations of the British Empire"?

In May 1930, Gandhi announced his decision to raid the salt works at Dharasana. Immediately, all the prominent Congress leaders including Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, and Sardar Patel were arrested. However, Sarojini Naidu and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad led the peaceful agitation.

The Satyagrahis were arrested in large numbers and the British did not hesitate to use brute force to suppress them. American journalist Webb Miller has left a poignant eye-witness account of the incident.

This is what he wrote: *"Suddenly, at a word of command, scores of native police rushed upon the advancing marchers and rained blows on their heads with their steel-shod lathis [batons]. Not one of the marchers even raised an arm to fend off the blows. They went down like ten-pins. From where I stood, I heard the sickening whacks of the clubs on unprotected skulls. The waiting crowd of watchers groaned and sucked in their breaths in sympathetic pain at every blow. Those struck down fell sprawling, unconscious or writhing in pain with fractured skulls or broken shoulders. In two or three minutes the ground was quilted with bodies. Great patches of blood widened on their white clothes. The survivors without breaking ranks silently and doggedly marched on until struck down…They marched slowly towards the police. Although everyone knew that within a few minutes he would be beaten down, perhaps killed, I could detect no signs of wavering or fear. They marched steadily with heads up, without any possibility that they might escape serious injury or death."*

6. Webb Miller's account appeared in 1350 newspapers across the world. What impact do you think this would have had on world opinion about British rule in India?
7. What do you think gave the Satyagrahis the inner strength to face this brutality?

Judith Brown writes, Gandhi "grasped intuitively that civil resistance was in many ways an exercise in political theater, where the audience was as important as the actors."

Gandhi himself wrote in 1920, "The religion of non-violence is not meant merely for the rishis and saints. It is meant for the common people as well. Non-violence is the law of our species as violence is the law of the brute... The dignity of man requires obedience to a higher law – to the strength of the spirit…"

Photo: gandhiserve.org, https://commons.wikimedia.org

8. Do you agree that Satyagraha was, in reality, nothing more than "political theatre"?
9. Do you think human beings are fundamentally non-violent? Think of the long history of wars down the ages. How does this make you feel about Gandhiji's philosophy of life and his commitment to his beliefs?

Gandhi said, "An eye for an eye only ends up making the whole world blind".

He argued that violence only begets greater violence. Non-violence, on the other hand, in his own words "does not mean meek submission to the will of the evil doer, but it means putting of one's whole soul against the will of the tyrant. Working under this law of our being, it is possible for a single individual to defy the whole might of an unjust empire." "My ambition," he wrote, "is no less than to convert the British people through non-violence and thus make them see the wrong they have done to India."

10. In view of Gandhiji's role in our freedom struggle, do you agree that a single individual can defy the might of an empire?
11. Do you think he fulfilled his ambition to make the British see the wrong they had done to India?

Saza – E – Kalapani

The very name Cellular Jail in Port Blair, Andaman Islands, was enough to send shivers down the spine of even the bravest of the brave. It was the most dreaded prison where freedom fighters were incarcerated by the British Raj.

In the aftermath of the Revolt of 1857, the British considered the remote islands a suitable place to punish those who had fought against them. The prisoners were used as labourers to do construction work. But by the end of the 19th century, as the freedom struggle picked up, the British felt the need for a high security prison that would give the convicts suitably harsh treatment. The outcome was the construction of the Cellular Jail between 1896 – 1906.

Originally the Cellular Jail had seven wings, each three storeyed and all were connected to a central tower. This tower also served as a watch tower from where the guards could keep vigil on all the wings.

The wings were constructed in such a manner that the front of one wing faced the back of another, so that one inmate in a wing could not see or communicate with another inmate in any of the adjacent wings.

Each cell housed only one prisoner thus isolating them. Even the cells in a wing were in a row so that inmates in the same wing could not see each other. There were 693 cells.

This feature of solitary confinement in individual cells earned the jail its name, "Cellular".

1. Why do you think the jail was designed in such a way that the prisoners would not be able to see or communicate with each other?
2. How would you feel if you had to spend weeks and months without seeing anyone? Write down your thoughts.

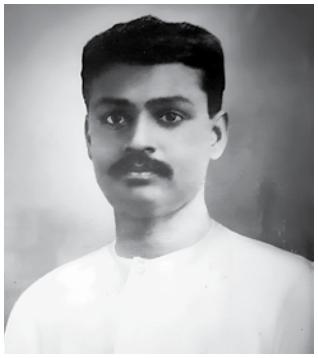
Look at the picture. It shows you that the locks of the prison cells were designed in such a way that the inmate would never be able to reach the latch of the lock. Even if the inmate would try to put his hand out and try to unlock the door, he would never be able to do so.

3. Imagine you are a prisoner in the Cellular Jail. Would you try to escape? Write a paragraph on what you would do.

The revolutionaries who were imprisoned in the Cellular Jail were not treated as political prisoners but were treated worse than ordinary criminals. All kinds of torture from the jail authorities ranging from backbreaking manual work and terrible food to the hurling of abuses and flogging were the routine. Many freedom fighters in the jail went through inhuman torture.

4. Do you think that political prisoners should be treated like criminals and tortured? Give reasons for your answer,

Batukeshwar Dutt



Sachindranath Sanyal

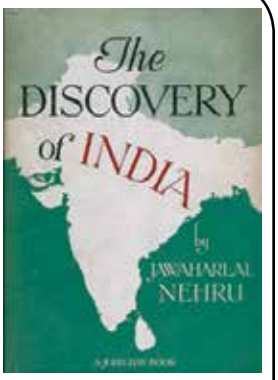
Vinayak Damodar Savarkar
(Popularly referred to as Veer Savarkar)

These were some famous freedom fighters who were incarcerated in the Cellular Jail. The jail inmates observed hunger strikes in the early 1930s to protest against the miserable conditions in the jail. They were tortured, some were beaten to death, some hanged themselves, some tried to escape and were caught and executed.

The gallows in the Cellular Jail – 3 prisoners could be hanged at a time.

5. If you were to write a book today about India's history, where would you get your information from?

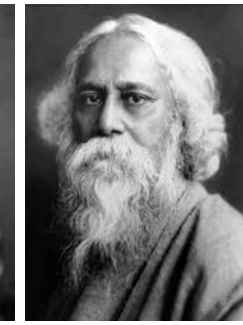
Did you know?



Jawaharlal Nehru spent 3259 days (that is, almost 9 years!) in jail. He was incarcerated for varying lengths of time in different jails – mostly in Allahabad, Dehradun, Lucknow, Almora, Ahmednagar and Bareilly.

During his imprisonment in Ahmednagar from 1942-45, he wrote the masterpiece *The Discovery of India* which traces India's history from the Harappan Civilization down to the last years of the British Raj. In writing the book Nehru drew upon his vast knowledge of Indian history, philosophy and culture as well as conversations with his fellow prisoners, especially Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Govind Ballabh Pant and Asaf Ali. They also participated in proofreading Nehru's work and providing him with creative suggestions.

6. What do you think gave the prisoners the strength to bear the long years of torture and suffering? Imagine that you are a prisoner – write a journal describing your thoughts and feelings.



Gandhiji and Rabindranath Tagore led a campaign demanding that the British authorities shut down the jail and by 1939, the prisoners were repatriated. The jail was declared a national memorial in 1979 and is open to the public. Its museum gives visitors a glimpse of the struggle of our freedom fighters.

Bravehearts!

Quiz time!
Look at the pictures below and find a connection between the five great people (other than the fact that they were all freedom fighters).

Mahatma Gandhi

Subhas Chandra Bose

Maulana Azad

Jawaharlal Nehru

Rani of Jhansi

Did you know? Five regiments of the Azad Hind Fauz (Indian National Army or INA) were named after them.

The Rani of Jhansi Regiment was the first all-women regiment in the history of the Indian Army. It was composed of Indian women who were recruited from Southeast Asia, mostly from Singapore and Malaya.

1. You must have read about Rani Lakshmibai who fought against the British to defend her kingdom Jhansi in 1857-58. Why do you think 85 years later, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose named the women's regiment after the Rani of Jhansi?

Lakshmi Swaminathan

The regiment was led by Lakshmi Swaminathan (later Lakshmi Sahgal) – or Captain Laksmi as she was called.

Isn't it a remarkable coincidence that the Captain of the Rani of Jhansi regiment was a woman named Lakshmi!

She was a 28-year-old doctor and during the surrender of Singapore to the Japanese, she helped the prisoners of war. In July 1943, when Subhas Chandra Bose arrived in Singapore, she met him and got his consent to set up a women's regiment of the Indian National Army.

Netaji believed that unless women played their part in the freedom struggle, India could not hope to be free. He said famously, "In the last and final War of Independence, we want not one but thousands of Ranis of Jhansi."

2. Do you think that as we celebrate 75 years of freedom, women in present day India are as emancipated as the Ranis of the INA?

Janaki Thevar, aged just 18, became the second-in-command. There is a famous anecdote about her. When Netaji came to Kuala Lumpur, she cycled to the rally without telling her parents. When he called for donations, she went up to the stage, took off her gold earrings and necklace and gave them to him. She hoped that her parents would not notice her missing ornaments, but the next morning there was a picture of her handing over the jewellery to Netaji on the front page of the local newspaper!

3. Something to think about – What would you be willing to give up for a cause – say for our nation or to save the environment or for the welfare of an underprivileged child?

Subhas Chandra Bose upheld two role models for the women soldiers in the INA – Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi and Joan of Arc of France.

Joan of Arc

Joan of Arc was a controversial personality in her time. Today, she is honoured as a saint and defender of the French nation, but back in the 15th century, she was accused of heresy (going against the beliefs of the church) and burned at the stake at the age of about 19. The "wrongs" she was accused of included wearing men's clothes and carrying arms.

4. As you can see, norms of dressing change with the times. What is perfectly acceptable in our times was not acceptable earlier. Can you think of more examples from Indian history?

Netaji reviewing the Rani of Jhansi regiment – beside him is Captain Lakshmi.

The "Ranis" wore smart khaki uniforms – Jodhpur breeches with tucked-in bush shirts and black buckled shoes. The cap was the same as the one worn by the male soldiers of the INA.

When the Japanese heard about the Rani of Jhansi regiment, they were amazed. The senior military officers considered women soldiers an absurd thought and their training a waste of ammunition.

However, the regiment fought bravely against the British. During the retreat of the forces in Burma (now Myanmar) they had to march in perilous conditions carrying their rifles and heavy backpacks – wading through mud and crossing deep rivers where the water rose up to their necks, while the skies were filled with enemy airplanes raining bombs. Sadly, they did not get an opportunity to fight on Indian soil.

Listen to the beautiful lyrics of the anthem of the Provisional Government of Free India here. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WRgrmM_NBUo

Listen to the rousing marching song of the Indian National Army here. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J4K5rzCybr0

Flag of Azad Hind

"In the entire history of World War II, there is no other example of such a force, led by and composed of women," writes Sumantra Bose in his book *Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's Life, Politics & Struggle*. "Even today, women participating in actual combat is very rare anywhere in the world, and all-women military units are practically unheard of."

The Rani of Jhansi Regiment remains an important symbol of women's participation in the struggle for Indian independence, and its legacy has inspired generations of women in India and beyond.

5. What inspiration do you draw from the bravehearts who were part of the Rani of Jhansi regiment?

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